

HSL748-Guidelines

May 6, 2026

Guidelines

The "Primary Technique" Test Ask yourself, "What is the specific trick that makes this joke funny?" If you remove or alter that specific element, does the joke completely lose its punchline? The element that bears the load of the humor is the primary technique.

1. Read the entire setup and punchline without over-analyzing. Identify where the "laugh" or the "pivot" happens. 2. Isolate the Technique: Determine exactly how the setup and punchline are associated in the timeline.

Category Definitions

1. Elaboration

Definition: The setup and the punchline may seem incongruent or unrelated in conventional reading, but the activation of a stereotype/ reference of the element in the setup elaborates and explains the punchline. The elaboration is often exaggerated or hyperbolic (the incongruent part) or a metajoke.

What to look for: A clear setup hosting an element, followed by a punchline that makes sense by referring to a salient stereotype/reference of that element.

Example: Why was the anti-vaxxer's 4 year old child crying? Midlife crisis. (Stereotype- normative and not necessarily true)

"Scientist: ""My findings are meaningless if taken out of context."" Media: Scientist claims ""Findings are meaningless."" (Reference to setup)

Everyone tells me 8 hours of sleep isn't enough. They always tell me I need to sleep 3x more. (Exaggeration)

2. Synergy

Definition: The humor arises from the simultaneous activation of two incongruent elements with a common ground from the set of sound, spelling, meaning or concept (including stereotype and reference). The two interpretations must be active at the same time WITHOUT negating one another.

What to look for: One or more elements in the setup and one element in the punchline with two simultaneous interpretations *or* There is one element in the setup and two interpretations in the punchline that coexist

Example: Why couldn't the poor man donate at the sperm bank? He was too low income (Phonetic and conceptual elements synergy)

What do you tell someone who has diarrhea and anxious at the same time? "Don't lose your shit" (Literal and phrasal meaning)

Why did Margaret Thatcher hate the Trade Unions? Because they include u and i but not her. (spelling and phonetic synergy)

How do you make pickled bread? You use dill dough. (One element in setup, 2 interpretations in punchline. Often phonetic and conceptual synergy doesn't require 2 elements)

3. Recalibration

Definition: The humor is obtained through the mental recalibration from setup to punchline. Setup may set an expectation, and punchline would subvert it. Discarding one interpretation over the another. Alongside both interpretations subject to being active at the same time, the recalibration provides more of a laughter.

What to look for: An element in the setup with a conventional interpretation, and an element in the punchline bringing out the unconventional interpretation.

Example: Without the Arabs we wouldn't have 9/11. We would have IX/XI instead

You know what the biggest problem with political jokes is? They get elected.

I got cancer. or was it crabs? what's the picture look like?

4. Absurdity

Definition: The humor occurs because there was no joke/ no intention to create a joke, like a straightforward statement, anti-joke or absurdly incongruent elements that doesn't follow from setup to punchline.

What to look for: Element in the setup is highly congruent with element in punchline, doesn't cause any mental recalibration or activation of multiple interpretations.

Example: Why did the bed cross the road? Because he wanted to send e-mail from space and there were no telephone poles. (Absurd)

Why did the Chicken Cross the Road? To get to the other side (Anti-joke)

Miscellaneous

Definition: The joke does not fit neatly into the above categories. Use this only if you don't get the joke/ don't find any suitable category.

Overlap Resolution (Why This, Not That)

Quite often a joke can appear to be in more than one category, or appear unclear which category best suits it. But the reduction of categories to elements and techniques provides us with a hierarchy for which the joke can fall under.

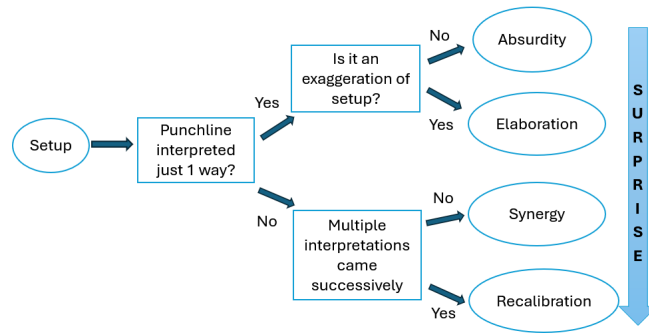


Figure 1: Complexity and hierarchy of joke

Since most of the one-liners can be play on words, try to focus on what the wordplay is achieving.

Example: I have a fear of over-designed buildings. I have a complex complex complex. Complex complex complex activates multiple concepts associated with the polysemy of complex, exaggerated by the stacking complex. no recalibration. Can fit into both Elaboration and synergy, but all encompassing category is **Synergy**

Example: What spell do Harry Potter characters use to have an abortion? Fetus Deletus

If you get just one interpretation it could be because you see this as a stereotype on Harry potter **Elaboration**.

However, if Harry Potter and abortion, two incongruent concepts, feel connected by an interpretation that gives spell vibes and also the procedure of abortion, it could be a bit higher and for you and be **synergy** .

Example: Something disturbing came in the mail today. It was the mailman.

If you focus on the double interpretation of "came in the mail", it is **synergy**. But if you had one interpretation of "came in the mail" that changed after reading the punchline, it is **Recalibration**.

The interpretation that comes after a recalibration may or may not coexist with the previous interpretation.

Example: How do you say good bye to two hundred thousand Indonesians? A big wave. In this, both of wave's meanings come one after the other (recalibration), and they coexist at the same time (synergy), and the punchline is also an elaboration of stereotype about Indonesians (elaboration).

If all criteria are satisfied, the best choice would be to choose the one that encompasses all the interpretations. **Recalibration** can accommodate all of these explanations, hence can be the best category for this joke.

Example: If someone stole a Tesla, Would it be called an Edison? (Concept synergy, Tesla the inventor and vehicle + reference of stealing. No recalibration, so synergy could be the best category here).

Labels to be Used

- Anti-humor- A
- Elaboration- E
- Synergy- S
- Recalibration- R
- Miscellaneous- M